



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Lafayette Academy

School Website: <https://lafayetteacademy.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Lafayette Academy MO 63367 presents a clearly classical orientation across most dimensions of governance, curriculum, and pedagogy, with strong emphases on virtue formation, a liberal-arts curriculum, and Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy in the upper grades. Public materials frequently highlight the school's classical identity, Great Books orientation, primary-source history, teacher-led instruction, and a four-virtue framework. There is explicit attention to truth, virtue, and wisdom as central aims, and to limited use of screens in favor of active, memory- and discussion-based learning. However, several elements that would push the school toward a fuller, traditional classical profile—explicit theology or liturgical practice, a stated trivium-based curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric), and a more explicit “living curriculum” faculty framework—are less prominent in the public-facing materials.

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Key evidence driving this assessment includes:

- Clear classical framing and liberal-arts content in mission and program descriptions, including virtues and a long-standing classical posture (Fortitude, Justice, Prudence, Temperance) and a rhetoric-oriented upper school path in some materials.
- Strong emphasis on “great books,” primary-source history, and Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy in upper grades, plus explicit statements about forming minds and character through a classical liberal-arts program.
- Explicit public statements about “teacher-led, low-tech classrooms,” strong literacy pedagogy, and the avoidance of screens, which align with scholé/restful aspects and memory-focused practices.
- Evidence of active parental engagement and open events (e.g., prospective open houses, tours), but comparatively less explicit articulation of parents as co-teachers or a formal “living curriculum” faculty portrait in public materials.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials emphasize virtue and transcendent aims in character formation (Fortitude, Justice, Prudence, Temperance) and a claim that education should form mind and character, guided by a classical tradition. Public texts repeatedly frame virtue and truth as core aims and cite a four-virtue framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: truth, virtue, wisdom, Fortitude, Justice, Prudence, Temperance (these terms appear in the materials).
- Negative keywords present: none identified in the public materials (e.g., no signals of relativism, secular humanism, or values clarification).

Why this rating

- The school foregrounds virtue and truth as enduring, knowable ideals and frames character formation as central. However, explicit theology, liturgical practice, or a clearly stated transcendent metaphysical anthropology is not overtly documented on the public-facing materials, limiting a full category 1CLASSICAL rating. The lexical indicators strongly support virtue-centered, transcendent-oriented aims, but the theology/liturgy dimension is not clearly present in the visible content. Therefore, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is warranted.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Mission emphasizes virtue formation and human flourishing within a classical liberal-arts framework and a long tradition of classical education. Texts indicate aims to seek truth, practice virtue, and lead with wisdom, with an emphasis on formation rather than purely information.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, great conversation, classical mission, telos, scholé (where referenced), permanent questions. The school explicitly connects the aim of education to virtue and to knowing truth, goodness, and beauty.
- Negative keywords present: none identified in public materials (e.g., no emphasis on workforce-prep or 21st-century-skills framing in this category).

Why this rating

- The materials consistently present education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, anchored in a liberal-arts framework and a classical mission. This aligns closely with the classical-purpose criteria. The absence of explicit, competing modern workforce framing strengthens the CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Curriculum is described as liberal arts-oriented with a range of subjects (language, literature, mathematics, history, government, geography, science, music, art, Latin) and an emphasis on Great Books, primary sources, and Western civilization. There are explicit references to “true history using primary source documents,” “Socratic texts,” and a Great Books emphasis in several pages.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, Great Books, primary sources, classics, Western civilization, history, Latin, rhetoric, grammar/logic (explicitly less frequent in the public copy but the Great Books/primary-source cadence is strong). Public materials also mention “true history using primary source documents” and “the four classical virtues” as curricular anchors.
- Negative keywords present: none identified in the public materials for this category (no explicit shift to social studies framing or project-based dominance in place of classical history).

Why this rating

- The school foregrounds liberal-arts content and the Great Books/primary-sources tradition. While the public copy does not always spell out the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as explicit curricular modules, it strongly aligns with a classical curriculum through Great Books, primary sources, and Western-civilization emphasis, supported by the rhetoric around forming minds through a classical liberal-arts program. This justifies CLASSICAL in Curriculum.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence



- Pedagogical approach includes contemplative/restful elements (scholé) and memory-focused methods (singing/chanting in lower grades; memorization and recall), along with upper-grade Socratic discussions, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training. Public texts explicitly reference Socratic discussion in upper school and opportunities to give speeches and use rhetoric training; lower grades feature singing and memory-based review.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic, seminar, dialectic, disputation, narration, recitation, chanting, memory work, scholé, liturgical/calendar integration, rhetoric, debate, public speaking. The Lafayette site mentions Socratic discussions and rhetoric training in upper grades, as well as chant/memory-driven lower-grade activities.
- Negative keywords present: minimal to none; the site does not emphasize project-based, experiential-only models or constructivist harms in this category.

Why this rating

- The pedagogy described aligns closely with classical pedagogy: contemplative/restful elements co-existing with rigorous, memory-based, Socratic/seminar-driven instruction in the upper grades and rhetoric-focused activities. The combination supports CLASSICAL in Pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Faculty are framed as capable and virtuous, with references to teachers delivering strong content and guiding character, and to job postings seeking mastery of academic disciplines and commitment to classical aims. Public materials emphasize high-quality teachers, books, and student effort, but explicit language about the faculty constituting the “living curriculum” or a formal teacher portrait is not always present in the public copy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: model teachers and mentors; living curriculum (concept appears in the lexicon but is not consistently stated as public language), teachers as core to formation; collegial culture; portrait of a teacher (not explicitly stated on Lafayette’s site but implied through emphasis on teacher quality and leadership). The Careers page notes teacher mastery and content focus.
- Negative keywords present: none explicit in public materials (no mentions of non-classical faculty models like “facilitators on the side” or “certification-driven jargon” in the Lafayette copy).

Why this rating

- The school communicates strong teacher quality and subject-matter mastery, with a clear classical mission, but it does not consistently articulate a fully explicit “living curriculum” faculty portrait or a fully fleshed-out classical faculty culture in public-facing content. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Faculty.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school actively engages parents via open houses, tours, admissions inquiries, and financial-aid information. The public materials show outreach to prospective families and ongoing events; however, explicit statements about parents as co-teachers, formal parent formation programs, or a robust “open campus” with guidance in classical formation are less visible. Open houses and admissions contact are clearly present.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with parents (concept implied by open houses and tours), parent formation/seminars (the lexicon includes parent-forming activities; Lafayette's content shows booklets and information sessions, though not necessarily formalized as "parent formation" modules). Open-campus and events exist; parent involvement is encouraged via open information channels.
- Negative keywords present: consumer-language signals or minimal parental involvement are not clearly present in public materials; however, explicit "parents as co-teachers" or structured "parent formation programs" are not strongly articulated.

Why this rating

- The school demonstrates tangible parental engagement (open houses, information requests) and welcoming practices, but it does not consistently articulate a formal, sustained parental-partnership program or a robust parent-formation framework in the public materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Parents & Community.

Aggregate assessment

- Category ratings:
- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Pedagogy — CLASSICAL
- Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Add explicit theology or liturgical / communal-worship language and practices in public materials (e.g., chapel, liturgy, sacred music) to strengthen the Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices criteria. Consider publishing a short section that ties virtue formation to a theology-informed anthropology and liturgical rhythm. This would elevate Element 1 toward CLASSICAL.
- Element 5 (Faculty): Publish explicit statements about the faculty as the living curriculum, a clearly articulated teacher-student formation model, and a formal portrait of the ideal teacher and student. Consider showcasing ongoing faculty development in classical pedagogy and a more explicit teacher certification/training pathway aligned with classical education.
- Element 6 (Parents & Community): Develop and publish stronger, explicit parent-formation programming (e.g., parent book clubs, study groups on classical pedagogy, home-liturgy alignment resources) and clearly position parents as co-teachers or collaborators in the educational formation of students. Expand policies and communications about open-campus opportunities and parent involvement in governance or advisory roles.
- Element 3 (Curriculum): If possible, publicly articulate and publish a Trivium-based articulation (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and ensure a public-facing outline that shows Great Books, Latin/Greek as appropriate, and primary sources as core curricular elements. Strengthen the explicit "Great Conversation" and canonical-reading commitments in all grade bands.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy): Maintain the strong Socratic/seminar approach, but codify and publicize a coherent pedagogy guide that ties memory work, recitation, and chanting to student outcomes and assessment, ensuring consistency across grade bands.

ABSTRACT

Lafayette Academy MO 63367 displays a robust classical orientation, with clear strengths in purpose (formation toward virtue and wisdom), curriculum (liberal-arts with Great Books/primary sources), and pedagogy (Socratic discussions, memory work, and a teacher-led, low-tech environment). The school's public materials emphasize the four classical virtues, a strong liberal-arts program, true history via primary sources, and a commitment to forming minds and character. There is evidence of parental outreach and community engagement, and a strong emphasis on virtuous living and a classical mission. However, explicit theology or liturgical practices, a formal Trivium-based curriculum, and a fully articulated "living curriculum" faculty portrait are not always evident in public materials, and explicit parent-as-co-teachers language is limited.

- Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (virtue-focused, with limited explicit theology/liturgy)
- Element 2: CLASSICAL (formation toward virtue and wisdom; liberal-arts orientation)
- Element 3: CLASSICAL (Great Books/primary sources; canonical Western history)
- Element 4: CLASSICAL (Socratic pedagogy, memory, rhetoric)
- Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (strong faculty emphasis but less explicit "living curriculum" portrayal)
- Element 6: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (parent engagement exists, but formal co-teaching/parent-formation articulation is limited)

Overall, Lafayette Academy qualifies as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Cited sources and keyword anchors

- Public declarations of independence-classical positioning, "independent, classical school," and the liberal-arts program: Lafayette Academy materials.
- Four Classical Virtues (Fortitude, Justice, Prudence, Temperance) and virtue-centered mission: public pages.
- Formation of mind and character; seeking truth, practicing virtue, leading with wisdom; Great Books/primary sources; Hillsdale support: public pages.
- Great Books, primary sources, true history, Socratic dialogues, and upper-school rhetoric: public pages.
- Lower- and upper-grade pedagogy (singing/chanting; memory; Socratic/seminar; rhetoric): public pages.
- Public references to parental engagement (open houses, inquiries) and admissions/tuition/financial-aid: public pages.
- Foundational keyword lexicon (positive/negative indicators for all six categories) to ground keyword analyses: `classicality_lexicon.v2.2.txt`.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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